Common Sense

Thomas Paine · January 1776 · excerpts

Source: Project Gutenberg, gutenberg.org/ebooks/147; original pamphlet, Philadelphia, 1776.

Published anonymously in Philadelphia in January 1776, Thomas Paine's pamphlet sold an estimated 120,000 copies in three months — extraordinary for a colonial population of about 2.5 million. Paine argued in plain language that reconciliation with Britain was impossible and that monarchy itself was illegitimate. The pamphlet helped shift colonial opinion from protest to independence in the months before the Declaration.

Connect: How does Paine's attack on monarchy build on the colonists' grievances from Class 2?

Key Passages

On monarchy

> There is something exceedingly ridiculous in the composition of monarchy; it first excludes a man from the means of information, yet empowers him to act in cases where the highest judgment is required.

On reconciliation

> Everything that is right or natural pleads for separation. The blood of the slain, the weeping voice of nature cries, 'TIS TIME TO PART.

On America's destiny

> We have it in our power to begin the world over again. A situation, similar to the present, hath not happened since the days of Noah until now. The birthday of a new world is at hand.

HAPP Analysis

Model answers fill the first three rows. Use them to explain the author's Purpose in the last row.

HAPP Element	Your Analysis
Historical Context *What was happening when this was written?*	Fighting had begun at Lexington and Concord (April 1775), yet many colonists still hoped to reconcile with Britain and blamed Parliament rather than the king.
Intended Audience *Who was the source written for?*	Ordinary colonists, including farmers, artisans, and laborers; it was written in plain language to be read aloud in taverns and homes.
Point of View *Whose perspective? Whose is missing?*	Thomas Paine, a recent English immigrant and radical, who had seen the British monarchy firsthand and believed all hereditary government was illegitimate.
Purpose *What did the author want to accomplish?*	

Analysis Prompts

1. SAQ practice: Identify ONE specific piece of evidence from Common Sense and explain how it advanced the cause of independence.

2. Why was Paine's plain, accessible style strategically important in 1776?

3. How does Paine's argument about monarchy connect to the Declaration of Independence six months later?